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ENGL-3050 Final Portfolio: Table of Contents

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Synthesis Letter

To begin, thank you for teaching this class the way you have because it allowed someone like me who had little knowledge of creative writing to learn at least the basics. Throughout the semester, I've come to realize quite a bit more about what writing styles I like to adopt when creating my essays. I've learned about a handful of creative nonfiction genres as well as the plethora of sub-genres that extend from them. I attempted to include aspects of some of them in my writing to see how it'd flow. I'd say that the most valuable thing I learned in this class is that everyone really will have their own versions of what they read in their head. I think it's important to make my writing not necessarily more straightforward, but more clear so as to guide the reader into the thinking that I had while writing. The most challenging bit of this class, in my honest opinion, was coming up with meaningful critiques of my peers' essays. I was always able to read and interpret all of them to a fair enough degree, but they were almost always great in my eyes so I feel like most of my critiques and suggestions weren't as well-made as they could've been.

The workshop process took some time to get used to. The small workshops felt a lot easier to me as both groups I was a part of figured it'd be best to allow the author to talk while the readers interpreted it. However, I think that the large workshops were better because I was able to get more people to voice their thoughts on my work rather than two or three people having to quickly come up with interpretations, critiques, and suggestions on the spot. Everyone who was in my large workshop group(s) gave me meaningful feedback for my essays but a few people gave exemplary responses. Aru Gupta was one such person. He would always find different ways for my essays to be enhanced whether it be through fixing my pacing to allow my story to flow better or by adding more necessary detail to better engage the reader. He is really good at giving suggestions that are genuinely helpful, at least to me. One other peer whose feedback was appreciated was Gabriel Unser's. He kept his interpretations and critiques short and blunt and I appreciated that. It allowed me to better understand how my writing might be interpreted. I tried to keep my own reflections of others' work fair for everyone. What I mean is I tried to give everyone a meaningful enough reflection of their work as I could. Oftentimes, it likely wasn't very good feedback that I was giving but I tried. My active participation in class for the workshops was very minimal, but I did make sure to write down all of my thoughts on their papers for them to review afterward.

The readings assigned to us throughout the semester all played a part in how I decided to write my own essays, but I also didn't really enjoy reading almost any of them. The first few felt uninteresting to me. However, John Green's "The Anthropocene Reviewed" was very fun to read. Almost every story within it was entertaining. His writing style kept me hooked and I genuinely looked forward to reading new chapters. I ended up attempting to adopt his style (I forgot what we called it) in, I believe, our first large workshop. I don't know if I would say the Reading Responses were especially useful for me, but they did force me to actually read and interpret the readings we had to do, which I suppose you could say is useful in and of itself as I ended up gaining knowledge of different styles of writing and how to keep readers entertained.

Truthfully, I have no future writing goals that I look forward to. I do believe that this class was useful, but I do not see myself writing creative nonfiction or anything else any time in the near future. As a result of this class, I find writing significantly easier as opposed to how I felt writing at the beginning of the semester. I believe that was a goal that I had hoped to improve on, so I suppose that is a plus. I also believe I might actually try reading more creative nonfiction

essays or just essays in general as I found that a lot of them are more entertaining or emotional than I had ever given them credit for.

It was definitely challenging to incorporate my own life into the writing I did. I have a notoriously bad memory so having to reflect on specific moments in my past was particularly hard, which is probably why I often decided to go for more philosophical writing. It allowed me to write less about myself (because most of the details are fuzzy). If I'm remembering correctly, the most difficult in-class writing prompt we had toward the beginning of class was to write about a memory we had but through someone else's perspective. I tried to write a basketball game I played in middle school where my team was doing horribly, but I ended up switching the perspective to several different people, which could've been interesting, but I just confused myself and gave up. If I were to write more, it'd likely just be random funny stories that have happened in my life (such as "Splat").

As for a grade, I think I might deserve either an A- or a B+. Although my participation in class was minimal, I did show up and do the work to the best of my ability. I read all of the readings assigned to us and tried my hardest to really understand them. As for workshops, I gave everyone my best interpretations and suggestions that I could come up with. I believe I missed two days, which falls under the three-day miss limit, and I did end up asking for the writing prompts we went over the one day because I wanted to do them. I would completely understand a B+ or even a B- for my lack of in-person participation, but I am hopeful for an A-.

Jared Krug

Changing Clouds (Revised)

Word Count: 301

I never used to pay much attention to clouds. They've always been there, drifting across the sky like the scenery in a play—important, but never quite the focus. Recently, though, I took a moment to really look up. I watched as the clouds moved with a slow, serene grace. Some stretched thin across the sky like strokes of white chalk, while others billowed thick and gray, shifting so subtly that their transformations were almost imperceptible.

That simple observation struck a chord. The quiet, steady movement of the clouds mirrored the way my own life has evolved. There was a time when each day felt unpredictable, as if I were floating aimlessly, uncertain of where I'd land. I remember nights spent sitting alone with a knot of worry in my stomach, the future an unanswered question that loomed larger with each passing moment. I'd wonder if I was doing enough to steer myself toward the life I wanted or if I was destined to drift forever.

But much like the clouds, change happened so gradually I hardly noticed it. The fears I once carried—of uncertainty, of failure—didn't vanish overnight. Instead, they shifted, shrinking with every small step I took. The unhurried pace of the clouds reminds me that transformation doesn't always arrive with commotion. Often, it comes in small, quiet waves, and I've learned to appreciate those gradual shifts as part of a broader journey.

Now, as I settle into a more predictable rhythm, I've come to realize that stability isn't the same as stagnation. Just as the clouds continue their steady progress across the sky, so do I. Even

if the changes ahead unfold at the same slow, unremarkable pace, I trust that growth will come.

The clouds have taught me to be patient with myself and with life's ever-changing skies.

Jared Krug

Changing Clouds (Original)

Word Count: 307

I've never paid very much attention to clouds. They've always been there, just hanging in the sky like a backdrop to everything else. Recently, however, I took a moment to really look up. I watched as the clouds moved with a slow and serene grace. Some were thin and wispy, while others were thick and gray, shifting around imperceptibly.

The fairly mundane observation struck a chord. The quiet, steady movement of the clouds seemed to mirror how my own life has evolved. My life used to be full of unknowns, but as time went on, I figured out what I wanted to do with it and I've begun settling into a routine. There was a time when each day felt unpredictable as if I were drifting through it, uncertain of where I'd land. I remember nights when I'd just sit and worry about the future and what I should be doing with it, often accompanied by a nagging feeling that I wasn't doing enough to get where I was supposed to be.

Much like the clouds in the sky, though, change happened ever so gradually that I had hardly noticed it. Things that I once feared such as uncertainty or failure didn't disappear overnight, but they shifted, slowly losing their weight as I took small steps forward. The clouds, moving at an unhurried pace, remind me that change doesn't always happen dramatically but in slow, mundane waves, and I've grown to appreciate the gradual shifts as I understand that each one is part of a broader journey.

Now, as I settle into a more predictable rhythm, I realize my newfound stability doesn't necessarily mean stagnation. Just as the clouds continue moving forward, so do I. Even if the

changes moving forward continue gradually, I understand that my growth will continue, just as the clouds keep moving forward.

Jared Krug

The Duality of Water (Revised)

Word Count: 627

Water is an extraordinary force of nature. It nurtures life, carves continents, and courses through every single living thing that this planet has to offer. We drink it, swim in it, navigate across it, and yet, as much as water continues to sustain us, it can also be just as merciless. Drowning, floods, storms. Its power can take life just as effortlessly as it gave it. To understand water is to accept its duality, which is to recognize both its beauty and its danger.

I learned this lesson firsthand one summer day when my sister and I almost drowned in a swimming pool.

It was a local pool, the kind families go to when the sun beats down too fiercely and the only escape is the cool relief of chlorinated water. My sister and I were young, maybe too young to truly understand the dangers of the deep end. We were laughing and having fun while playing a game we invented; the rules of which I can hardly remember now. All I know is that we ventured too far into the deep without noticing how our feet could no longer touch the bottom. What started as playful swimming turned frantic when we both realized, almost simultaneously, that we were in very deep trouble.

Panic set in like a switch flipped. I flailed, trying to push myself upward, but the water seemed to push back harder. My sister was beside me, her wide eyes mirroring my own terror as we gasped for air between gulps of water. It felt as though the pool had come alive, a vast, unfeeling force pulling us down. My chest burned, my arms ached, and every thrash seemed to sink us deeper.

The sound of splashing and muffled screams filled my ears until a red blur appeared—a lifeguard. Strong hands pulled me from the water and carried me to the edge. My sister followed, sputtering and coughing, her face pale but alive. We collapsed on the hot concrete, shivering despite the sun’s warmth. The entire ordeal lasted less than a minute, yet it etched itself into my memory with the clarity of a life-changing moment.

That day, I learned of water’s paradox. It sustains life, but its depths conceal danger. Oceans hold mysteries, rivers cut paths through rock, and rain brings renewal, but in an instant, all of it can turn destructive. The pool that almost claimed my sister and I was artificial, a controlled environment, and even there, it wielded its indifference with the same power as the wildest sea.

This experience instilled in me a reverence for water, and by extension, for life itself. Life, much like water, is delicate. It can be snatched away without warning, without reason. Yet, it’s the thing we trust implicitly, the thing we often take for granted. Perhaps that’s the lesson: what sustains us can also undo us.

Since that day, I’ve come to see life as a balance between trust and vigilance. We float along, buoyed by routines and certainties, rarely considering the depths beneath. But life, like water, is unpredictable. It demands respect. And yet, it also offers moments of pure joy—moments worth the risk of navigating its currents.

Whenever I’m near water now, whether it be a lake, a pool, or even a tiny stream, I remember the calm surface of that pool and the chaos hidden just below. I think of my sister’s hand reaching out, the lifeguard’s whistle slicing through the air, and the feel of solid ground beneath me once again. Above all, I remember the gratitude I felt to be alive.

Water remains an extraordinary force, its duality unchanged. It nurtures, sustains, and refreshes, but it can take everything away in an instant. That is its nature—and ours.

Jared Krug

The Duality of Water (Original)

Word Count: 796

Water is an extraordinary force of nature. It nurtures life, carves continents, and courses through every single living thing that this planet has to offer. We drink it, swim in it, navigate across it, and yet, as much as water continues to sustain us, it can also be just as merciless. Drowning, floods, storms. Its power can take life just as effortlessly as it gave it. To understand water is to accept its duality, which is to recognize both its beauty and its danger.

I learned this lesson firsthand one summer day when my sister and I almost drowned in a swimming pool.

It was a local pool, the kind families go to when the sun beats down too fiercely and the only escape is the cool relief of chlorinated water. My sister and I were young, maybe too young to truly understand the dangers of the deep end. We were laughing and having fun while playing a game we invented; the rules of which I can hardly remember now. All I know is that we ventured too far into the deep without noticing how our feet could no longer touch the bottom. What started as playful swimming turned frantic when we both realized, almost simultaneously, that we were in very deep trouble.

The thing about drowning is that it happens slowly at first and then all at once. There's this moment of confusion, a sense of disbelief that something so simple, something we had taken for granted our whole lives, could betray us so completely. One second you are in control, then the next, you are being consumed by something far greater than yourself.

I remember the fear beginning to creep in as we flailed, gasping for breath between gulps of water. My sister's face was a reflection of my own wide-eyed desperation. Panic is an overwhelming sensation, and in that instant, it felt like the water was alive, like it had decided that we weren't going to leave it. Down it dragged us, unrelenting.

It was a few moments later that a lifeguard managed to pull us out, a hero with red shorts, carrying us back to the safety of the pool's edge. We sputtered and coughed, our lungs burning, but we were alive nonetheless. The whole ordeal had lasted less than a minute, but it etched itself into my memory with the weight of a near-death experience.

Water is a paradox. It sustains life, but its depths conceal danger. Oceans hold mysteries, rivers cut paths through rock, and rain brings renewal, but in a moment all can turn destructively overwhelming. The pool that almost claimed us was artificial, a controlled environment, and even there, it wielded its indifference with the same lethality as the wildest sea.

This experience instilled in me a reverence for water, but also for life in general. Life, much like water, is delicate. It can be snatched away as quickly as it is given, sometimes without warning, without rhyme or reason. Yet, we need it in the same way that we need water. It is the essence of survival, the thing we get up every morning and assume will always be there without giving it much thought. And perhaps that's the point of it. The things we need most, the things we trust implicitly, are often the ones capable of undoing us.

That near-drowning incident with my sister reminds me that danger can arise from the most familiar places, and that survival is never guaranteed. In life, most of the time, we tend to focus on the surface, on what we can see and control. We don't always consider the depths, about

the unseen forces that swirl beneath our everyday existence, ready to pull us under if we're not careful.

Perhaps that's the challenge of life, navigating through water and time. It is the balance between trust and vigilance, between enjoying what we have and being aware of the risks. Water gives life to every cell in our bodies, yet it doesn't promise security. Similarly, life offers us moments of joy and wonder, but it doesn't promise us safety. We can do no more but try to stay afloat.

Now, whenever I'm near water, whether it be a lake, a pool, or even some minuscule stream, I am reminded of the ease with which it can turn from playful to perilous in mere moments. I think of that day in the deep end with my sister, the water's calm surface concealing the danger beneath. And I think of how grateful I am to have escaped and learned a vital lesson that life, like water, is both precious and volatile. As much as it nurtures, sustains, and refreshes, it can take it all away in just one wink of time.

Jared Krug

Splat (Revised)

Word Count: 346

On a warm afternoon when I was seven, I found myself at Beck Park, my neighborhood's well-loved playground. Kids raced between the slide, the swings, and the seesaw, their voices weaving into a cheerful hum. Beyond the playground, a narrow creek wound through the park, its shallow water broken up by a few concrete slabs. They looked as if they'd been placed there for crossing but forgotten in a haphazard line. A small group of kids were already daring each other to hop across, wobbling as they went.

When the last kid made it to the other side, I stepped forward, my turn to test the slabs. I planted my sneaker on the first one, arms stretched out for balance as I leaped to the next. The slabs were uneven and just far enough apart to make every step a mini adventure. Below me, the creek gurgled softly, its cool voice adding to the thrill of the jumps.

The final slab was the trickiest, a slightly tilted one that wobbled under my weight. I managed to leap to the far bank with a triumphant grin, only to be startled by the sudden flap of wings overhead. Before I had the chance to glance up, I felt a wet, warm *splat* landing squarely on my head.

"You've got to be kidding me...", I muttered, frozen for a moment as reality sank in. I could feel the sticky mess clinging to my hair. The nearby chatter of kids seemed to pause, and when I glanced sideways, I caught a mom trying, and failing, to stifle her laugh.

My cheeks burned as I took off running, weaving through the forest paths on the other side of the creek. Twigs snapped beneath my feet, and every shadow felt like another bird ready

to strike. I eventually escaped the small forest and after sprinting the five blocks back to my house, I burst in, panting and still horrified.

That quick visit to Beck Park? It turned into a sprint home, proof that even the simplest adventures can lead to messy surprises.

Jared Krug

Splat (Original)

Word Count: 330

On a warm afternoon, I found myself at Beck Park, our neighborhood's well-loved playground. Kids raced between the slide, the swings, and the seesaw, their voices weaving into a playful hum. I wandered past a row of benches, toward the small bridge that spanned the narrow creek cutting through the park, where a few misplaced concrete slabs sat scattered in the water, as if remnants of some forgotten project. A few kids were already testing their balance on the slabs, daring each other to cross.

I waited until the last kid scrambled to the other side, then took my turn, stepping cautiously onto the first slab. My shoes scraped on the gritty surface as I hopped to the next, steadying myself with arms outstretched. The slabs weren't lined up perfectly, forcing each step to be just a bit of a leap. I glanced down at the water, hearing its soft trickle below, each jump giving me a slight thrill.

Finally, I made it back to the bank on the other side, and as soon as I got myself situated, a sudden flap of wings directly above startled me. In the split second before I looked up, I felt a wet, warm *splat* of bird poop on my head.

"You've got to be kidding me..." I muttered as I came to realize what had just happened. Out of the corner of my eye, I noticed a nearby mom seemingly hiding a smirk as I stood there, half-laughing, half-horrified.

With a sigh of slight embarrassment, I took off through the maze of forest paths, my cheeks warm as I began running at a full sprint. Eventually finding my way out of the forest, I

continued running the five blocks back to my home which felt like an eternity given my situation. My quick visit to Beck Park had somehow turned into a quick dash for the safety of my home, proving that sometimes, the simplest little adventures can turn into messy surprises.

Jared Krug

Learning Patience (Revised)

Word count: 704

Patience, as the saying goes, is a virtue—one I’ve had to stumble into learning. For me, patience wasn’t something I was born with; it was a skill shaped by a series of trials, from waiting rooms to college acceptances, each demanding more from me than the last. I’ve come to understand that time, when embraced instead of resisted, can transform from an enemy into an unexpected ally.

In life’s smaller, quieter moments, patience has often tested me in subtle, almost mundane ways. Sitting in a doctor’s office, for instance, can feel like a battle against time itself. You arrive on time, only to find yourself flipping through crinkled magazines, each passing minute a reminder that life rarely moves at your preferred pace. Then there’s the peculiar frustration of waiting for new seasons of a favorite show. Months stretch out between announcements and releases, and each teaser feels like a taunt. These moments are fleeting but familiar, small reminders that not everything bends to your timeline.

The real lessons, though, came when the stakes were higher. When I was eight, I learned patience the hard way after fracturing my arm. It happened during a daring leap from a playset—one of those leaps where, mid-air, you realize you’ve miscalculated. Gravity had the last laugh, leaving me with a blue-and-white cast that stretched from my knuckles to my elbow. Worse than the pain or inconvenience was being sidelined from my summer basketball league, the one thing I looked forward to all year.

Basketball was everything to me back then. I begged my mom to at least let me practice layups with my left hand, but she didn't budge. "You'll thank me later," she said, her tone final. At the time, I didn't see the wisdom in waiting. All I saw were days crawling by, each one taunting me with the sound of dribbles and cheers from the court I couldn't join. I sat on the sidelines, casting envious glances at my teammates. Looking back, though, that summer taught me the value of letting things heal—not just physically, but emotionally. Rushing wouldn't have sped up the process; it would have made it worse.

Years later, I faced a different kind of waiting, one that felt just as interminable. During my final semester of community college, I applied to Iowa State University. By all accounts, my acceptance was likely—I'd met the requirements, and their acceptance rate was high—but doubt has a way of sneaking in. What if something went wrong? I pinned my hopes on that acceptance, checking the application portal daily, refreshing it obsessively, each update—or lack thereof—fueling my anxiety.

When the acceptance finally came, the relief was immense. Yet, as I reflected on those weeks of waiting, I realized something important: patience isn't just about enduring the wait; it's about finding steadiness in the face of uncertainty. Waiting doesn't mean doing nothing—it means trusting that you've done all you can and letting the rest unfold.

Patience, I've learned, often arrives as an unwelcome teacher, showing up when you're least prepared. Its lessons sneak into the cracks of life, like the doctor's office, the fractured arm, or the college portal. But in those moments of stillness, I've found something unexpected: clarity. Waiting has a way of stripping away the noise, forcing you to confront what's within your control and what isn't.

When I was younger, waiting felt like wasted time, a void where nothing happened. But now I see it differently. Waiting is a process, one that stretches your capacity to sit with uncertainty, to make peace with not knowing. It's not just about enduring; it's about making space—for possibilities, for growth, for forces beyond your control to work their magic.

I won't pretend I've mastered patience; far from it. There are still moments when waiting feels unbearable, when I want to push fast-forward in life. But each time I'm forced to wait, I remember the lessons that have shaped me. Whether it's sitting in a doctor's office or refreshing a portal, waiting has taught me resilience, perspective, and the quiet power of trusting the process. And in those in-between moments, I've found something worth holding onto, the understanding that life, in its own time, always moves forward.

Jared Krug

Learning Patience (Original)

Word count: 953

Patience, as the saying goes, is a virtue, and for me, like most, I had to experience it to learn it. Circumstances or perhaps my conscience, disguised as life's impersonal forces, conspired to teach me this much-belated lesson, among others. Learning to wait and its long and interesting history has come to my attention in different rounds, from summer leagues to college applications, and with the passage of time, I have also come to understand that time can be the greatest friend and not the enemy.

The first major lesson in patience that I can recall came at eight years old, courtesy of a fractured arm. I'd been climbing a playset when I decided to jump from too high up, almost daring gravity to do its worst. I came to realize mid-fall that I hadn't exactly stacked the odds in my favor. The result was a bright blue and white cast that ran from my knuckles to my elbow, but more devastatingly, I was forced into a hiatus from playing in my community's little league summer basketball league. Basketball was my world back then, and I often dreamed of achieving a career in the NBA sometime in the future. However, with my right arm out of commission, I couldn't practice, or play, and worse, I had to watch from the sideline as my teammates continued the season without me.

I remember the frustration vividly. It seemed so unfair that I had to wait, to feel like I was missing out on everything while my arm very slowly healed. I tried pleading with my mom, claiming that I'd be fine using my left hand for layup practice. She wasn't convinced. Looking back, that waiting period was crucial. Rushing my recovery would've only prolonged the time

away from the court that I so longed for. But at eight, all I knew was that the days crawled by, marked by moments of me staring at my cast and willing it to disappear. That stretch of time was probably my first real lesson in patience. Sometimes, no matter how badly you want to fast-forward time, you just have to let things take their course.

Years later, the stakes were different, but the waiting game remained. I applied to Iowa State University while finishing up my general education at community college. Even though I knew Iowa State's acceptance rate was really high, I still felt a knot of uncertainty. What if something went wrong? I'd pinned most of my plans on getting in, and that "what if?" loomed larger the longer I waited. I checked the application portal compulsively, hoping for any update, as each day that passed without an answer felt like a small eternity. I went from optimism to doubt and back again pretty frequently.

When I finally saw that I'd been accepted, the relief washed over me, and all those anxious days suddenly felt distant, almost comically unnecessary. Looking back, I realize that those weeks were more than just idle waiting, they were a chance for me to acknowledge the reality of my own uncertainty. I couldn't control when the decision would come or what it would be, and that uncertainty alone taught me something valuable about patience. It isn't only about enduring the wait. It is also about staying grounded when you feel untethered, finding stability in knowing you've done your part and accepting that the rest is out of your hands.

This "learning patience" theme has constantly resurfaced in smaller, everyday ways as well. Take doctor's appointments for example. Most of us have been there where we're sitting in the exam room, trying not to think about the 30 minutes you've already waited past your appointment time. It acts as a little reminder that not everything moves at the pace you'd like and that even if you're in a rush, life has no obligation to hurry for you. Then there's also the

annoying wait for new seasons of the shows I watch. They're always announced with teasers that make it seem like they're just around the corner, but months go by before they finally get released. It's like a test of patience in a weird, modern way, one that somehow feels different than waiting for something significant.

More than anything, learning to wait has shown me that patience is about more than just enduring, it's about perspective. In the moments of forced stillness, whether it's staring at a cast, refreshing a college application portal, or idly scrolling on my phone in a doctor's office, I've had to confront that part of me that feels like things should happen on my schedule. But life has a way of showing you that it's not going to follow your agenda. The best you can do is accept the pace and make the most of the in-between moments.

When I was younger, I used to think of waiting kind of like a void, a gap in time where nothing happened. Now, I see that waiting itself is a process, one with lessons that often go deeper than the outcome we're waiting for. It stretches our capacity to accept uncertainty, to find peace in the unknowing, and to realize that the world will keep turning even when we don't have all the answers. Waiting isn't always about passively biding time, it's also about making space for what could be, for unseen forces to do their work. Patience, as it turns out, isn't just sitting around, it's staying steady when the path isn't clear. And though I won't say I always enjoy waiting, I can appreciate what it offers: resilience, perspective, and the understanding that the journey is no less valuable just because we had to wait for it.